failure of Indian shipping companies.[51] Responding to this charge, Krishna Aiyangar, reiterated that the company's directors were businessmen and regular shippers.[52] Though conceding that managing a shipping company was 'a new thing', he was emphatic it had 'to be tackled newly under the circumstances'. In a pointed reference, he said three years was time enough to understand the management of a ship. When the chair of the committee argued that in Britain it took between fifteen to twenty years to understand shipping management thoroughly, Krishna Aiyangar replied that he was talking only of coasting streamers, adding that the Swadeshi ships had European officers also.[53] It needs no restating that the Tuticorin merchants launched on this enterprise as a result of external pressure—the hostile attitude of BI—with the rise of the Swadeshi movement providing the impetus.

Let us now turn to who the major investors and shareholders were.

In the last chapter, mention was made of the Sena Vana Company which chartered the steamers. Allusions were also made to four other traders who were involved in the venture initially, and references made to 'a syndicate'. The transition from Sena Vana Company to the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company is fuzzy but undoubtedly the former transitioned into a newly registered joint-stock company. Though their unity would soon break as VOC shifted to a higher political gear, credit must be given to all the Tuticorin traders who initially invested in the company when the horizon was not visible, the winds were uncertain and the undercurrents treacherous.

With the vacillating S.V. Nallaperumal Pillai taking a backseat after the first initiatives, entered Pandithurai Thevar. Pandithurai Thevar is still remembered as a great patron of Tamil language and literature. A first cousin of Bhaskara Sethupathy, the Raja of Ramnad, he had taken over as zamindar of Palavanatham in 1884. Educated in a missionary school, he was also a fine scholar, versifier and connoisseur of Tamil. By establishing the Madurai Tamil Sangam in 1901, he institutionalized support for the development of Tamil, and it could be said that there was no worthwhile